

and destructive energies. The Red King refused to unleash the magic contained within, having been warned by its creator that such an act would consume everything that existed, including their own kind. The treasure brimmed with such magic that even while contained it caused rains of fire and acid vapors to consume enemies for miles around and, with a single strike, the Red King shattered mountains.

Just as everything seemed lost, a group of Tuathan forces managed to enter the Red King's encampment and engage the Fomorians' leader in combat, using every ounce of strength and magic possible to ward off his attacks. Through a stroke of luck, or perhaps through intercession by the Dreaming itself, the Red King fell, but his heart was so full of rage that his dying soul lashed out against his own weapon, shattering it into nine pieces that scattered across the world. With their leader defeated, and the loss of their fearsome weapon, the Elder Dark and their minions surrendered. To prevent their enemies from ever returning among mortals and wielding the direct powers of the Dreaming, the Tuatha de Danaan left three Sacred Oaths to guide the fae, before entering the Dreaming never to be seen or heard from again.

Events become history. History becomes legends. Legends become myths, and myths are forgotten. Centuries passed as fae continued the efforts of the Tuatha de Danaan. While humanity continued to develop, adapted new ideals, and built larger settlements, the fae followed suit. Some fae found companions according to magical aptitudes and others gathered over shared interests, but regardless of friends and relatives, the majority paid allegiance to one of their newly-formed courts.

Trusting humanity to continue in their set ways as directed by them, the fae turned to their own kind and left mortals to fend for themselves. The brutal nature that gave form to the Fomorians still festered in humans. Without their guides, it surfaced, causing conflicts to erupt. Faerie society was not immune to this either, so when mortals went to war, so did the courts. Modern fae historians disagree as to whether these courts were the Seelie and Unseelie that changelings of today understand, or some primitive versions thereof. Some of the historical references they found seem to indicate *four* courts, not just two. What is not in question, however, is that these courts spent centuries fighting each other.

Though the fae never acknowledged it on the few occasions they took a look at the world around them, humanity continued to develop and grow on its own. By learning to control fire they adapted it to cooking, crafting, and metalworking, until one day someone created the first cold iron object, the very weakness of the Dreaming itself. In the same moment, the armies of the fae engaged in the Battle of Stones, which came to a halt as the world sundered beneath their feet, and separated dream from flesh forever.

The Sundering

It's impossible to say with certainty what initiated the Sundering, whether it was truly the act of humans discovering cold iron, or if the fae committed some sort of atrocity that the Dreaming saw fit to punish. While it took place over the

course of almost a millennium, the initial blast of the Sundering ripped magic out of the world, separating the Dreaming from the mundane permanently. Religions told mortals to worship new gods and to turn away from old traditions and rules. The fae spent so much time infighting that humanity simply forgot. They forgot their old promises and oaths to the children of the Dreaming and, as their stories faded, humanity's age dawned.

Kithain refer to the following centuries as the Dim Years, a suitable name for a bleak period in their history. Although the worlds separated, trods — roads infused with Glamour — made it possible to travel between the Dreaming and the Autumn world. Fearing that the Sundering meant the end of days, the fae spread across the world using the faerie roads to reach places humanity wouldn't lay eyes on for centuries. While this exodus meant establishing contact with the Gallain and other faerie creatures far away from the center of Banality, it also weakened the courts centered around Europe and Mesopotamia.

Courts turned to using changelings as spies and tools for learning. Some were children of dalliances with mortals, others were babies exchanged (stolen, really) by the fae. Mortal flesh became a shield against the new threat, and the true fae cloaked their souls inside magical copies of human bodies when venturing out into the Autumn Realm. Through these subtle machinations, the courts hoped to find possibilities to fulfill old oaths and stem the tide of Banality.

Officially, the war between the courts never ended, but combat was limited, and the fae focused on recovering both from the Battle of Stones, where they lost all their prominent leaders, and Banality's impact on the Autumn world. However, wherever mortal conflicts flared, the courts saw opportunities to strike at their enemies by using ongoing events as cover for their actions. Without realizing it, the fae worked at the very edge of mortal history, not creating, but following it.

In 1230 an eclipse covered much of the Autumn world, but while that would pass unnoticed by fae, this one also blotted out all light in the Dreaming. Panic over further human growth slowly spread in the courts. To protect themselves, many fae moved their holdings into the Dreaming to avoid contact with humanity, and in the process acted to further sever bonds between the dream and the flesh.

The Shattering

While the Sundering occurred over a long period of time, the Shattering happened quickly by faerie standards. Following the increasing stranglehold that Abrahamic religions held on the minds of mortals, the loss of true Dreamers to the stake and gallows, and the seclusion from the Autumn world, the bonds between the planes quickly deteriorated as Banality spread. Over the course of the next two centuries, trods and freeholds vanished, were destroyed, or were otherwise lost to the fae.

The courts went to war to determine who would control stable areas of the Dreaming, while freeholds continued to disappear, and it all culminated with the outbreak of the Black Plague, a disease many faerie scholars attribute to a broken oath between humanity and the Dreaming. Death and despair